THE AI-ENABLED DOCTORATE

Research Smarter. Think Deeper. Create Impact.

Sprint 2 Creative Storyboard Deck



Speaker: Akhil Menon

Resources

The opening question

Start with the problem they already know.

What organisational problem have you faced repeatedly... but never had the time, evidence or framework to investigate systematically?



AKHIL TIP #1

Experience becomes research only when it meets evidence.

Doctoral research is not a bigger report

It is a different way of thinking.

Common belief

- A thesis is a long document
- AI can make writing faster
- Research starts with a topic
- Doctoral work is mainly academic

Doctoral reality

- A thesis is evidence-based argument
- AI supports, but cannot judge
- Research starts with a problem
- Doctoral work must create impact

The core thesis of this webinar

A sentence the audience should remember.

AI can make you faster.

Only you can make your research meaningful.



Today is a mission, not a lecture

A 90-minute research upgrade path.

MISSION 1

Doctoral thinking

MISSION 2

PhD vs DBA

MISSION 3

Business research galaxy

MISSION 4

AI command centre

MISSION 5

Hands-on prompts

MISSION 6

Ethics check

MISSION 7

DBA pathway

MISSION 01

Think Like a Doctor

Before using AI, understand what doctoral thinking actually means.



From professional experience to credible knowledge

Doctoral research turns lived experience into transferable insight.



AKHIL TIP #2

A problem becomes doctoral only when it is evidence-worthy.

The doctoral thinking loop

Good researchers move in cycles, not straight lines.



PhD and DBA: similar rigour, different purpose

Avoid the “DBA is easier” trap.

PhD

- Primarily theory-oriented
- Often prepares for academic research careers
- Contribution to discipline knowledge
- Problem may be abstract or theoretical
- Publication and scholarly contribution emphasis

DBA

- Practice-oriented professional doctorate
- Designed for experienced professionals
- Contribution to organisational practice
- Problem emerges from real managerial context
- Evidence-based recommendations and impact

Same topic, two doctoral pathways

Example: AI adoption in hospitals.

PhD lens

- What theory explains clinical AI acceptance?
- Can existing technology adoption models be extended?
- How does this refine academic understanding?

DBA lens

- Why is AI adoption failing in this hospital network?
- Which factors influence clinician trust and workflow fit?
- What implementation framework can improve adoption?

AKHIL TIP #3

Same topic. Different purpose. Different question.

A DBA is not a shortcut

It is disciplined research with an applied destination.

01 Real organisational problem

02 Scholarly literature base

03 Robust methodology

04 Evidence-based analysis

05 Actionable contribution



AKHIL TIP #4

Different purpose does not mean lower rigour.

MISSION 02

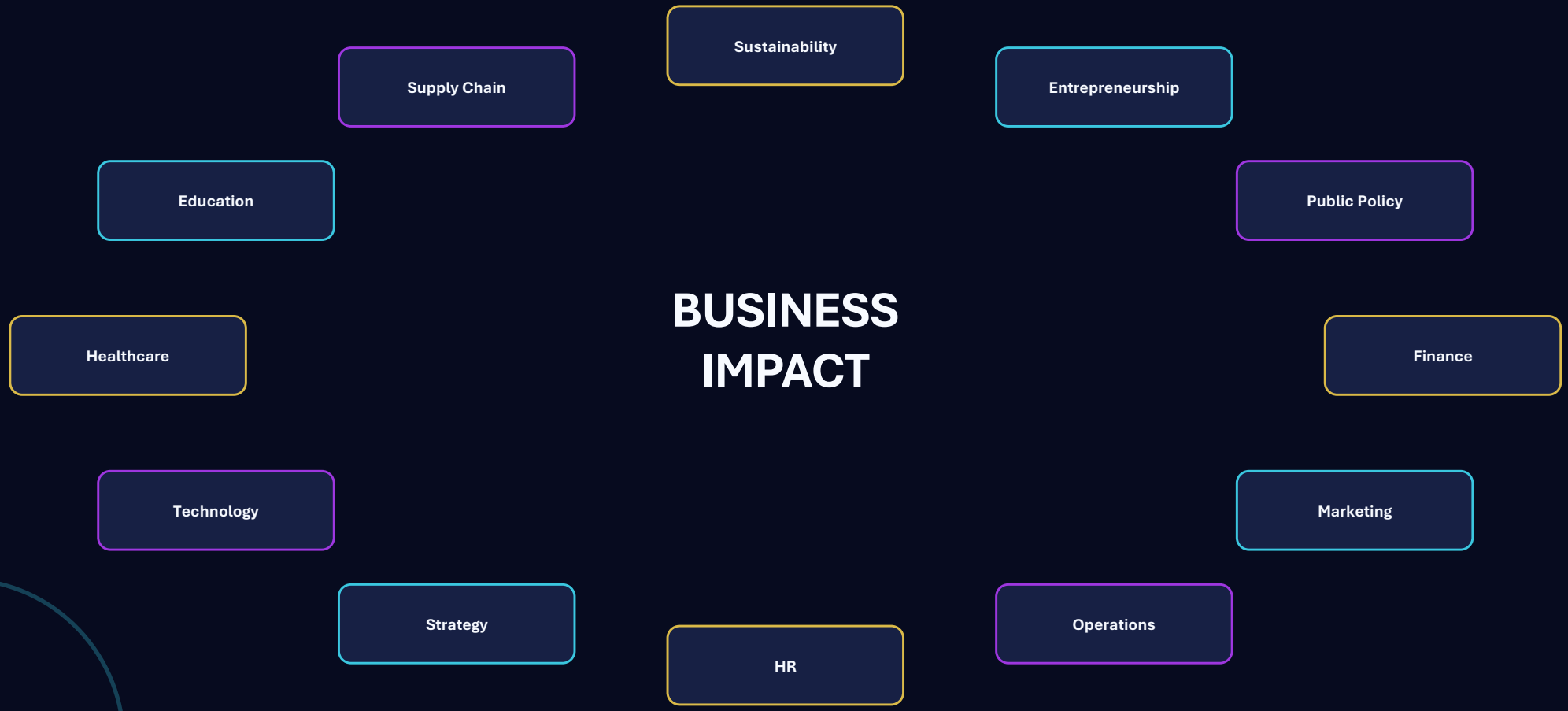
Enter the Business Research Galaxy

Every business function contains doctoral research opportunities.



The Business Research Universe

A DBA begins when professional problems become researchable.



Finance research opportunities

From financial control to intelligent decision systems.

- Financial analytics
- Credit risk
- Fraud detection
- Treasury decisions
- Working capital
- ESG reporting
- Cost optimisation
- Investment behaviour
- Audit quality
- FinTech adoption

DBA angle

How can AI improve managerial financial judgement without hiding risk?

Marketing research opportunities

Customer behaviour is now data-rich, fragmented and algorithmic.

- Consumer behaviour
- Brand trust
- CRM effectiveness
- Digital campaigns
- Customer experience
- Pricing analytics
- Influencer marketing
- Retail analytics
- Personalisation
- Customer loyalty

DBA angle

When personalisation increases sales, does it also damage trust?

People, HR and leadership research

AI is changing how organisations hire, evaluate and retain talent.

- Recruitment AI
- Employee engagement
- Leadership behaviour
- Performance systems
- L&D effectiveness
- Compensation fairness
- Hybrid work
- Attrition prediction
- Culture analytics
- Managerial trust

DBA angle

Can AI predict attrition ethically, or does prediction itself change behaviour?

Operations and supply chain research

Where efficiency, resilience and quality meet evidence.

- Inventory planning
- Demand forecasting
- Lean systems
- Quality control
- Procurement
- Last-mile delivery
- Maintenance
- Process mining
- Capacity planning
- Supplier risk

DBA angle

Can predictive systems reduce delays without creating fragile operations?

Strategy, entrepreneurship and innovation

The DBA as a vehicle for strategic problem-solving.

- Business models
- Scaling ventures
- Platform strategy
- Innovation adoption
- Competitive advantage
- Strategic agility
- Corporate entrepreneurship
- New product success
- Family business
- Market entry

DBA angle

What strategic decisions can be improved when experience meets evidence?

Technology, data and digital transformation

Researching the systems that now reshape management.

- AI adoption
- Cloud migration
- Cybersecurity
- Data governance
- IoT systems
- Robotics
- Automation
- Digital maturity
- Analytics culture
- XAI

DBA angle

Technology is rarely the problem alone; adoption, trust and process fit matter.

Healthcare, education and sustainability

High-impact domains for evidence-based professional research.

Healthcare

- Patient experience
- Hospital operations
- Clinical workflow
- Telemedicine

Education

- Learning analytics
- Assessment design
- Faculty development
- EdTech adoption

Sustainability

- ESG behaviour
- Circular systems
- Green operations
- Carbon decisions

Research Opportunity Matrix

Move from business pain to DBA-worthy inquiry.

Business Function	AI Opportunity	DBA Research Direction
Finance	Credit default prediction	Explainable AI in credit-risk decisions
Marketing	Customer churn	Personalisation and loyalty in subscription services
HR	Attrition	Ethical people analytics and retention
Operations	Demand volatility	AI-assisted demand forecasting in supply chains
Education	Student drop-off	Learning analytics for learner persistence
Healthcare	Workflow delays	AI adoption and clinician trust

How to recognise a DBA-worthy problem

Not every irritation is research.

Recurring	It appears repeatedly across situations.
Consequential	It affects performance, people, money or strategy.
Evidenceable	Data or participants can support investigation.
Theorisable	It connects to existing concepts and literature.
Actionable	Findings can influence managerial decisions.

From problem to preliminary research direction

A simple framing canvas for participants.

Context

Write one sentence here

Stakeholders

Write one sentence here

Symptoms

Write one sentence here

Possible causes

Write one sentence here

Evidence available

Write one sentence here

Possible contribution

Write one sentence here

AKHIL TIP #5

Do not ask AI for answers before you have framed the problem.

MISSION 03

Build Your AI Research Command Centre

AI is useful only when placed inside a disciplined workflow.



AI across the doctoral research lifecycle

Where AI can support, accelerate and organise.

- Topic exploration
- Problem framing
- Literature search
- Conceptual map
- Method design
- Data preparation
- Analysis support
- Writing support
- Presentation

AKHIL TIP #6

AI is a research assistant, not the researcher.

Green, yellow, red: AI responsibility zones

The practical ethics rule for everyday research work.

GREEN

AI can assist

Keyword generation, brainstorming, grammar, summarising your own notes

YELLOW

AI can support with supervision

Theme extraction, coding suggestions, interview questions, argument structure

RED

Do not delegate

Original contribution, source verification, ethical judgement, final interpretation

Human judgement checkpoints

Where the scholar must remain in control.

01 Selecting the problem

02 Choosing theory

03 Approving sources

04 Designing methodology

05 Interpreting evidence

06 Claiming contribution

07 Making ethical decisions



Prompt engineering for doctoral scholars

A prompt is a research instruction, not a magic sentence.

Role	Act as a doctoral research mentor
Context	I am studying employee burnout in IT services
Task	Generate possible DBA-level research questions
Constraints	Do not invent citations; mention limitations
Output	Give a table with variables, stakeholders and approach

Live Demo 1: Business problem → research direction

A controlled demonstration, not an uncontrolled AI show.

Prompt skeleton

```
I am a professional working in [industry/function]. A
recurring challenge I observe is [problem]. Help me
identify five DBA-level research questions. For each,
mention stakeholders, variables, practical significance
and suggested approach. Do not invent evidence or
citations.
```

What to watch for

- Generic outputs
- Over-wide scope
- Missing variables
- Weak stakeholders
- No feasibility check

Hands-on Activity 1

Turn your business problem into a research question.

1 min	Write one recurring workplace or industry problem
3 min	Use the structured AI prompt
3 min	Choose one generated question
4 min	Improve it using human judgement
2 min	Share one before/after in chat

How to critique AI-generated research questions

AI output is the draft. Your judgement is the upgrade.

Clear?

Focused?

Researchable?

Feasible?

Relevant?

Ethical?

AKHIL TIP #7

Never accept a research question just because it sounds academic.

MISSION 04

Map the Literature Without Getting Lost

AI can organise exploration, but scholars must verify sources.



Literature search begins before searching

Good keywords reduce wasted reading.

Core concept	Context	Population	Intervention	Outcome
burnout, stress, wellbeing	IT services, healthcare, education	employees, managers, faculty	AI workload tools, flexible work	retention, engagement, performance

AI-assisted literature map workflow

Use AI to structure search, not to fabricate citations.



Keywords	Boolean strings	Database search	Source verification	Theme clusters	Annotated notes	Research gap
AI can assist	AI can assist	AI can assist	Scholar verifies	AI can assist	AI can assist	AI can assist

AKHIL TIP #8

Ask AI for search strategy. Never ask it to invent references.

Research tool ecosystem

Each tool has a different job.

ChatGPT / Claude

Thinking, drafting, prompts

Perplexity

Current web-backed exploration

Google Scholar

Broad scholarly search

Scopus / WoS

High-quality indexed literature

Research Rabbit

Paper discovery networks

Connected Papers

Visual literature graphs

NotebookLM

Work with verified source files

Zotero / Mendeley

Reference management

Live Demo 2: Literature exploration without fake citations

The goal is search readiness, not automatic referencing.

Prompt

```
Create structured keywords and Boolean search
combinations for the topic “[insert topic]”.
Organise them under core concept, context,
population, intervention and outcome. Do not
generate references.
```

Verification routine

- Paste only search terms into databases
- Open actual papers
- Check author, title, year, DOI
- Store in Zotero / Mendeley
- Summarise only verified PDFs

MISSION 05

Hunt Hallucinations and Protect Integrity

AI can sound confident even when it is wrong.



The hallucination problem

The most dangerous AI output is not ugly. It is beautiful and false.

Looks impressive

- Perfect grammar
- Academic tone
- Confident phrasing
- Formatted references
- No visible warning signs

May still be false

- Invented papers
- Wrong claims
- Misquoted authors
- Fake DOI
- Unsupported conclusion

Ethical AI traffic light

A quick decision tool for doctoral scholars.

Acceptable	Grammar check; brainstorming keywords; improving clarity
Questionable	AI-generated themes without validation; uploading sensitive data
Unethical	Fake references; ghost-written thesis sections; invented data

Hands-on Activity 3: Ethical AI Check

Classify each case: acceptable, questionable, or unethical.

CASE 1 Using AI to correct grammar in your own paragraph

CASE 2 Asking AI to create references for a literature review

CASE 3 Uploading confidential interview transcripts to a public AI tool

CASE 4 Using AI to generate possible interview questions

CASE 5 Using AI to analyse data without understanding the method

A practical AI-use disclosure mindset

Do not hide responsible AI use; document it.

Purpose

Why was AI used?

Tool

Which tool or model?

Input

What data was shared?

Human review

How was output checked?

Limitations

What risks remain?



MISSION 06

Methodology, Data and Academic Writing

AI can support the mechanics, but methodology demands understanding.



AI and research methodology

AI can explain options, but cannot choose responsibly for you.

Quantitative

Surveys, models, statistical testing, prediction

Qualitative

Interviews, observations, thematic interpretation

Mixed Methods

Combining breadth and depth

Case Study

Context-rich investigation of a bounded case

AKHIL TIP #9

Methodology is not selected by popularity. It is selected by the question.

AI in data preparation and analysis

Useful support, but dangerous without statistical or domain understanding.

AI can help

- Clean messy labels
- Generate code snippets
- Suggest visualisations
- Summarise descriptive findings
- Explain statistical concepts

Scholar must decide

- Whether data is valid
- Which method is appropriate
- What assumptions apply
- What findings mean
- What claims are defensible

AI and academic writing

Use AI to improve clarity, not to outsource thinking.



Your argument

Human-owned

AI clarity support

Support step

Human verification

Support step

Supervisor feedback

Support step

Final scholarly voice

Human-owned

AKHIL TIP #10

Your thesis must sound like you at your most disciplined, not like AI at its most generic.

AI as a viva and defence preparation partner

A safe and powerful use-case when done honestly.

Challenge my research question as an external examiner.

Ask me five difficult questions about my methodology.

Identify weaknesses in my conceptual framework.

Help me explain my contribution in simple terms.



MISSION 07

From Doctoral Learner to Scholar-Practitioner

The DBA journey is structured, demanding and professionally meaningful.



The DBA learner journey

From admission interest to professional impact.

Eligibility

Research interest

Proposal

Coursework

Literature review

Methodology

Data collection

Analysis

Thesis

Viva

Impact

Structured supervision + milestones + peer learning + applied research

For existing DBA scholars

Three things to do immediately after this session.

1 **Rewrite one research question using the quality check.**

2 **Build one verified keyword map before reading more papers.**

3 **Create an AI-use log for transparency and discipline.**

For prospective doctoral learners

How to decide whether a DBA fits your goals.

Do I face complex organisational problems?

Do I want to convert experience into evidence?

Do I have a domain where I can collect or access data?

Do I want scholarly credibility with practical impact?

Am I ready for disciplined long-term research?

DBA FIT

If most answers are yes, discuss your research interest with the programme team.

Continue the journey

Resources, prompts and updates will live beyond today’s webinar.

Resource Hub

- AI prompts for doctoral research
- Research question quality checklist
- Tool list and workflow templates
- Business research opportunity matrix
- Upcoming talks and updates

akhil2453.github.io/akhil-portfolio

Connect on LinkedIn: Akhil Arun Menon

AI will not replace researchers.

But researchers who master AI will redefine research.



Thank you

Akhil Menon • The AI-enabled Doctorate